

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN KYRGYZSTAN

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In early 2019, when word spread that a company had begun exploring for uranium at **Kyzyl-Ompol**, near the cherished shores of **Lake Issyk-Kul**, the people of Ton district did not wait. They protested, and the protests spread — to the lakeside town of Balykchy, and then to the capital, Bishkek, in front of parliament itself. Activists launched a petition and gathered nearly thirty thousand signatures in days. Within weeks, the prime minister ordered the work suspended, a deputy prime minister stood before the protesters and declared the project shut, and **parliament voted to ban uranium and thorium mining across the whole country**. The company withdrew. A people who remembered what uranium had done to their land under the Soviets — the country still lives with the wreckage of Soviet uranium mining, dozens of abandoned tailings dumps and radioactive burial sites, many around Mailuu-Suu, that still seep into soil and water — and who would not gamble their sacred lake, had stopped a mine and outlawed a whole industry in a single season. From the first protests to the national ban was a matter of a few short weeks — the signature of how a Kyrgyz fight is won.

A community in Kyrgyzstan facing a harmful project works with real tools, and — as Kyzyl-Ompol showed — a government that fears the street can be moved fast. Major projects need an **environmental impact assessment and licensing**, a real gate a defective study can be challenged at. As a party to the **Aarhus Convention**, Kyrgyzstan owes the public **rights to environmental information, participation, and justice**. **Parliament and the legislative process** can suspend, cancel, or even ban — as they did with uranium — and protest, petition, and litigation are lawful and have won here. The **courts** can enforce these where they function, and **Lake Issyk-Kul's Biosphere Reserve** and other protected designations shield valued places. And the most powerful argument of all is the **living memory of Soviet uranium poisoning and the fierce national attachment to the sacred lake** — not ordinary environmental arguments but national reflexes felt across every region and generation, which a campaign that grounds itself in them can gather a whole nation around, fast. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. Kyzyl-Ompol's deepest lesson is a hard one: a fast, protest-driven win can be fragile and even reversed, and a government that yields to the street on one issue will suppress or ignore a protest it judges it can — so the space is not fully open, and it has lately narrowed, with real risk to activists. The national reflexes work powerfully for uranium and the sacred lake, but less so for other harms. And the courts and institutions are not always reliable. So the work must be careful: where the reflexes and the mechanisms align it can move a government fast; where they do not, it needs the patient use of the assessment, the Aarhus rights, and the law. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — a project assessed, suspended, cancelled, or even banned, grounded in the memory, the lake, and the law — while guarding the win against reversal and protecting everyone in a narrowing space.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You win here as Kyzyl-Ompol did — by grounding a fight in the national reflexes that rouse the whole country (the remembered poison and the sacred lake) and backing them with the mechanisms: the environmental assessment, the Aarhus rights, parliament, and the law. A government that fears the street will move fast to defuse a genuine, broad-based cause. But guard the win against reversal, use the law to make it durable, and, where the reflexes are weaker, rely on the patient mechanisms — and protect

everyone in a narrowing space.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Kyrgyzstan is a distinctive setting: a country whose governments fear the street, where a rightly-framed fight can win in weeks — but where the space has narrowed and a win can be reversed. Honesty about both is the first discipline. The national reflexes — the memory of Soviet uranium, the love of Issyk-Kul — are powerful for the issues they touch, less so for others; a protest-driven win can be fragile; the government suppresses when it judges it can; and the courts are not always reliable. So aim at the winnable — a project assessed, suspended, cancelled, or banned — grounding it in the reflexes and the mechanisms, guarding it against reversal, and protecting everyone.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

A Kyrgyz project runs through several powers, and — distinctively — the street. The **government and its ministries** grant the licences and can suspend a project. **Parliament** can cancel or ban, as it did with uranium. The **environmental and licensing authorities** administer the assessment. The **courts** review the legality where they function. And, decisively, a **roused public** can move all of them fast, because governments here fear the street. Map who decides — and whether the national reflexes are engaged — before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A mine or project needs an environmental assessment and a licence. That assessment and the Aarhus participation rights are one entry point; the licence another; parliament a third; and the street a fourth and, at Kyzyl-Ompol, decisive one. Where the harm touches the national reflexes — uranium, the sacred lake — a fight can rouse the nation and move the government in weeks. Where it does not, enter patiently through the assessment, the Aarhus rights, and the law.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the licence: who holds it, what the assessment says, and whether the Aarhus information and participation rights were honoured. Follow the harm: whether it touches the reflexes — the memory of uranium poisoning, the sacred lake — that can rouse the nation. Follow the reversibility: whether a win, once gained, can be undone. The leverage lies in the assessment and Aarhus rights, the legislative power, the courts, and the national reflexes.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The watchers are the environmental and licensing authorities, parliament, the courts where they function, and — as a party to Aarhus — the public itself, owed information, participation, and justice. And behind them stands the roused nation, which governments here have learned to take seriously. A case engages these, grounding itself in the reflexes where it can.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Opposition in Kyrgyzstan can win fast — Kyzyl-Ompol went from first protest to national ban in weeks. The single most decisive move is **grounding the fight in the national reflexes — the memory of Soviet**

uranium and the sacred lake — and backing them with the mechanisms, because a cause that speaks to the whole country at once moves a government that fears the street, and because the assessment, the Aarhus rights, and parliament can make the win real and durable. The national reflexes are the distinctive lever; the assessment and Aarhus rights the gate; parliament the decisive power; the law the guard against reversal. The realistic prize is a project assessed, suspended, cancelled, or banned — though a protest-driven win must be guarded, and works best where the reflexes are engaged.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the mine, the project, the threat to the water, the land, the lake. **Does it touch the reflexes?** — the memory of uranium poisoning, the sacred Issyk-Kul, that can rouse the nation. **What does it need?** — an assessment, a licence, honoured Aarhus rights. **Which mechanism reaches it?** — the assessment, parliament, the courts, the designation. **Can a win be reversed?** — and how to make it durable. Pick the fight where the reflexes are strongest and the mechanisms clearest — and, where the reflexes are weak, rely on the patient legal path.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Build the case in layers. **Layer one: the harm and the reflex** — the danger to the water, land, or lake, and its tie to the memory of Soviet poisoning or the sacred Issyk-Kul that rouses the nation. **Layer two: the process and the standard** — the assessment, the licence, the Aarhus rights honoured or denied, the designations breached. **Layer three: the durability** — how to make a win real through parliament and the law, and guard it against reversal. A case that grounds the harm in the national reflexes and backs it with the assessment, the Aarhus rights, and the law is one that can rouse the nation and hold.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the danger to the water, land, or lake, the science, and — where it applies — the tie to the remembered uranium poisoning. Gather the **process record**: the assessment, the licence, the Aarhus information and participation, the designations. Gather the **reflex record**: the memory of Mailuu-Suu and the Soviet tailings, the national attachment to Issyk-Kul. Gather the **durability record**: the legislative and legal means to make a win last. Kyrgyzstan's Aarhus obligations make much of the process record genuinely obtainable.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Kyzyl-Ompol's method — a local protest that grounds itself in the national reflexes and rouses the whole country — is the model. Build with the **affected community**, whose land, water, or lake is at stake; the **national public**, roused by the remembered poison and the sacred lake; the **activists and civil society** who can carry a petition and a campaign; and the **legal and technical experts** who can bring the assessment and Aarhus challenges and make a win durable. Frame the cause around the reflexes that speak to the whole nation — but be mindful of the narrowing space and the real risk to activists, and protect everyone.

STEP 4: THE REFLEXES, THE ASSESSMENT & THE LAW — WINNING FAST AND MAKING IT LAST

Set expectations honestly: a fight grounded in the reflexes can win in weeks, but the win must be guarded, and where the reflexes are weak the patient mechanisms must carry it.

The National Reflexes

The distinctive lever is the **living memory of Soviet uranium poisoning and the fierce attachment to Lake Issyk-Kul** — national reflexes felt across every region and generation. A fight that grounds itself in them speaks to the whole country at once and can move a government that fears the street in weeks, as Kyzyl-Ompol did.

The Assessment, the Aarhus Rights, and the Designations

Major projects need **environmental assessment and licensing**; the **Aarhus Convention** owes the public information, participation, and justice; and **Issyk-Kul's Biosphere Reserve** and other designations shield valued places. These are the mechanisms that back the reflexes and reach harms the reflexes do not touch.

Parliament, the Courts, and Durability

Parliament can suspend, cancel, or ban, and the **courts** enforce where they function — the means to make a win real and durable, not merely a suspension that can be reversed. Pursued together — the reflexes, the assessment and Aarhus rights, and the legislative and legal power — these levers can win fast and make the win last.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the nation**: here is a threat to the sacred lake, or a return of the poison our land still bears — a cause for the whole country. **For the assessment authority**: here is a deficient study or a denied Aarhus right. **For parliament**: here is a harm to suspend, cancel, or ban, as with uranium. **For the courts**: here is the assessment, the Aarhus right, or the designation breached. **For durability**: here is how to make the win last, beyond a reversible suspension. **The golden rule**: ground the fight in the national reflexes that rouse the whole country, back them with the assessment, the Aarhus rights, and the law, and guard the win against reversal — while protecting everyone in a narrowing space.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media is central — it was Kyzyl-Ompol's engine. Frame the story around **the national reflexes**: a threat to the sacred Issyk-Kul, or the return of the uranium poison the land still carries — a cause that speaks to the whole country. Carry it through the national press, the activist networks, and the petition. A few cautions: ground it in the reflexes and the facts; be mindful of the narrowing space and the risk to activists; make the case for durability, not just a reversible suspension; and let the memory, the lake, and the mechanisms carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message factual, grounded in the reflexes and the mechanisms, and mindful of the risk.

8A — To the government or ministry: set out the harm, its tie to the national reflexes, and the demand to suspend and reassess.

8B — To the assessment authority: flag the deficient study or the denied Aarhus right.

8C — To parliament: press for the suspension, cancellation, or ban, as with uranium.

8D — To the courts (through counsel): establish the assessment, Aarhus, or designation breach, and the durability of any win.

8E — On the Aarhus rights: demand the environmental information and participation the Convention owes.

8F — On a designation: invoke the Issyk-Kul Biosphere Reserve or other protection.

8G — To the activists and public: rouse the national campaign around the reflexes, carefully.

8H — To the press: frame the cause around the sacred lake or the remembered poison, and gather the nation.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: if the harm touches the reflexes, launch the petition and rouse the nation as Kyzyl-Ompol did; document the harm and demand the assessment and Aarhus information. **The fastest-moving levers:** the national reflexes and the roused public, backed by the assessment and parliament. **Emergency action:** a genuine, broad-based cause grounded in the sacred lake or the remembered poison can move a street-fearing government in weeks — but plan at once for durability, so a suspension is not quietly reversed. Throughout, ground it in the reflexes and protect everyone.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is unusual: a government that fears the street on some issues, and suppresses on others, in a lately narrowed space. Recognise it, and lean on the reflexes where they engage — the sacred lake, the remembered poison — which can move a government fast, and on the mechanisms — the assessment, the Aarhus rights, parliament, the law — where they do not. And accept the hard lesson: a protest-driven win can be reversed, the space has narrowed, and the government will suppress a protest it judges it can, so guard every win and protect everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — a licence steered to insiders, an assessment waved through, a foreign miner favoured over the sacred lake. Where capture appears, respond through the reflexes and the mechanisms: rouse the nation where the cause touches the lake or the poison, and press the assessment, the Aarhus rights, parliament, and the courts. **On safety:** Kyrgyzstan's space has narrowed, and there is real risk to activists, so while protest has genuinely won here, it must be undertaken with care; protect everyone involved, be mindful that the government suppresses when it judges it can, and guard against the reversal of a win. Care and durability are as important as speed.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps run in parallel, and — where the reflexes engage — fast. The harm and its tie to the reflexes feed the national campaign, the assessment challenge, and the legislative push at once; the community and public are roused; the law works to make a win durable. A rough timeline: **the first weeks**, where the reflexes engage, rouse the nation and demand suspension, as Kyzyl-Ompol did in weeks; **alongside and**

after, press the assessment, the Aarhus rights, parliament, and the courts to make the win real and durable; **beyond**, guard the win against reversal. The core discipline: reflex-grounded, mechanism-backed, durable, and protective of everyone.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Opposition in Kyrgyzstan carries a dramatic proof: Kyzyl-Ompol, where a local protest grounded in the sacred lake and the remembered poison roused the whole nation and, in a few short weeks, won a suspension, a declared shutdown, and a national ban on uranium mining. This guide has been honest that the win's speed is the lesson — but so is its fragility: a protest-driven win can be reversed, the government suppresses a protest it judges it can, the space has lately narrowed with real risk to activists, the national reflexes work powerfully for the lake and the poison but less for other harms, and the courts are not always reliable. A community that grounds its fight in the national reflexes that speak to the whole country, backs them with the environmental assessment, the Aarhus rights, parliament, and the law, and guards the win against reversal — while protecting everyone in a narrowing space — can win fast where the reflexes engage, and win patiently where they do not. The deepest lesson is Kyzyl-Ompol's: a Kyrgyz fight, rightly framed and grounded in what the whole nation feels, can gather a country and move a government with startling speed — and, made durable, can last.